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Rashied Ali & Henry Grimes

Percussionist Rashied Ali was born in Philadelphia on July 1, 1935. After military service and stints with rhythm & blues and hard bop artists, he immersed himself in the New York City jazz scene of the 1960s. Rashied continues to be an integral force in progressive jazz and currently performs with his own quintet in New York and overseas.

Bassist/violinist Henry Grimes was born in Philadelphia on November 3, 1935. He was in constant demand throughout the 1950s and 60s and recorded with Tony Scott, Gerry Mulligan, Sonny Rollins and numerous other artists. He became an integral part of the free jazz movement in New York before leaving music for three decades. His reentry into the jazz world in 2003 was a major event and has proven highly productive.

Rashied and Henry were interviewed in Clinton, New York on 1/30/09 before a duo concert at Hamilton, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming at Hamilton College for the Jazz Archive, and I'm really pleased to have Henry Grimes and Rashied Ali with me today, two of the most forward thinking people I've come to know, I think it's safe to say. Do you think of yourself as a forward thinking person?

RA: Well yeah, very much.

MR: I like to see a career where, you know if you look in the bios about you guys it will say that you played with this fellow and that fellow and this band, and now it's come to the point where if you look up people and lists that they've played with you.

RA: Well yeah, I guess, you know, we've been around the block a few times. So it's a lot of that going on there.

MR: I wanted to ask about a few current things before we sort of go back in time a little bit. Henry, did you just do something at the UN I read about?

HG: Yes we just did something that's going to be going on between New York and Jerusalem, where, a couple of months from now, and it's going to be all bassists in Israel and New York, I mean not Israel, Jerusalem and New York.

RA: How many bass players is that?

HG: Oh well —

RA: It's some Israeli bass players too?

HG: Yeah, a few Israeli and —

RA: Omer Avital, was he on that?

HG: Yeah, I don't know.

RA: Omer Avital, he's a great bass player from Israel.

MR: Is it called "Deep Tones for Peace?"

HG: Yeah "Deep Tones for Peace." You heard of it?

MR: I read it in your information. It sounds fascinating.

HG: Yeah it is.

RA: Hmm. That's interesting.

MR: And Rashied, I know you're happy, right now you've got your own quartet, is that right?

RA: Quintet actually, yeah. So you know, I have had many quintets since Coltrane's days, and this is, the one I have now is the most workingist one of all, because the other quartets, the quintets, whatever, trios, that I had since Coltrane, it was just that I was never, you know I'm not really good at hustling gigs on my own. So and I've never really had an agent before, maybe since five years ago now. So I've never really got a lot of work. So I really couldn't keep a band together very long without keeping them working. So I went through quite a few bands. But the one I have now since I've had an agent for the last five or six years, we've been together about four years now. And I'm very happy with it.

MR: What's a good month for you, as far as your band, as far as gigs?

RA: A good month?

MR: Yeah. How many times would you play?

RA: I would say in the spring and the fall and the summer months. The winter months aren't so good. The spring and the fall and the summer months are really good, especially in Europe, because they have a lot of outdoor festivals there and even in America they have a lot of outdoor festivals in the summer and springtime. And so I think most of it's good — spring, fall, summer is the best times.

MR: Let me ask you about growing up in Philadelphia. Henry, I think I heard that your parents were musicians.

HG: Yes, as much as I know about it is mainly hearsay. Because I came to hear music in the house it was when I realized that we had a piano, so I used to play it, and nobody else. My brother maybe, but I don't think he did too much though, but I did a little bit, and I never found out of they were really musicians or not.

MR: You don't know why they sort of got out of the business.

HG: No I don't. But I mean it seemed like a very — in fact they must have known some professional bearing years before.

RA: You know what became popular, I mean not popular but given over to musical, professional life.

MR: Was the radio part of learning music in those days for you guys?

HG: The radio?

MR: The radio. I mean did you listen to music?

HG: I used to listen to a lot of music from Dixieland up to about '53 when you'd hear Charlie Parker and Miles Davis and those kind of groups. But in between I used to listen to the Dorsey Brothers you know, like, and, you know, all those associated players like Gene Krupa.

RA: One of my favorites.

HG: I wanted to play with some of them that I never did play with them.

MR: Were you a Gene Krupa fan?

RA: Oh yeah. Man, I was definitely one. Music was in my family, my whole family, it's very musical. And so my whole life I remember listening to Billie Holiday when I was almost a toddler. So I mean like Charlie Parker, my father bought all those records, all those 78 records and stuff, from Dial labels and stuff. So music, I came up in music. My mother was a singer and my grandmother, she was a minister of a church. She had a little Holy Rolly Church, a corner church, and she had five daughters, my aunts, and they all played piano and they all sang in the choir at church, and I had piano lessons before I could almost walk. And so I listened to music my whole entire life. My uncles played professional music and they used to have sessions in the front room because there was a piano in my house of course. And also there was a piano in my father's family's house. So there was pianos in both places. I mean like in my mother's house and in my father's family's house, there was a piano downstairs, everywhere. And so I just started playing the piano and my aunt was a professional piano player at the age of around 12 or 13 years old. In fact, she was so good that Lionel Hampton wanted to take her when she was 14 years old but my grandmother wouldn't have it. She wanted her to finish school and not get involved in music, but she was that good. She won all those talent shows and stuff, and my mother, she sang with Jimmie Lunceford's band at a talent show, and we had a place in Philadelphia called the Earle Theater. And the Earle Theater was like, it was a theater that showed movies and then showed a live show, then a movie, then a live show. And I seen people like Sammy Davis Jr. when he was a kid playing with his uncle and his father, and Charlie Parker and J.J. Johnson, and everybody. Because we used to go to the Earle Theater all the time. You know, like that was a present from my mom, if we did our chores really good she would give us money to go down to the Earle Theater and sit down there for all day long and watch a movie and then listen to bands. So I was into music, even before I knew what music was.

MR: In watching those people, at the Earle Theater, did you say to yourself that's what I want to do?

RA: Oh I was in love with people like Sarah Vaughan and Billie Holiday. You know they were some of the most beautiful people I ever saw in my life. I would just sit there and just look at them and just be completely fascinated by them. And my uncle, he played

with like Jimmy Heath and John Coltrane and all those guys in Philadelphia. And they used to have sessions in the house. But I didn't really know who they were until I grew up. But he used to tell me that they used to come around Benny Golson and them, they used to come around and they used to play in the living room and sometimes they would put me out because they was doing things they didn't want me to see them doing. And I would go around the front of the house and I would pull myself up to the front of the window and watch them, and see my aunt, she died. She played piano. She was a very talented piano player but she died at childbirth, she was only 20 years old when she died. And her husband was a drummer. And so there was drums in my house. And I mean I was swamped. I couldn't have been anything else other than what I am. It was impossible for me to be — I never really did anything other than play music anyway, most of my life.

MR: Henry, did you get to the Earle Theater at all? Is that something that you would have done?

HG: Yeah I was. Yeah see it was in North Philly and I was in South Philly so I never got a chance in those places too much.

RA: Well you know where the Earle was, right? It was right on 11th and Market.

HG: Yeah. I'm familiar with it as, you know —

RA: See Market Street divided North Philly and South Philly, and I lived on the north side of Market Street, Henry lived on the south side, which was, you know, like Jimmy Heath and all those guys from there were from down that way. And Tootie and all those guys. Tucker, that's the drummer I was trying to tell you, Ronald Tucker. That's the drummer I was trying to think about the other day, he was from down your way, right?

HG: Yeah, Ronald Tucker, but I was thinking of another one, another guy. I know Ronald Tucker was one that was —

RA: Yeah, Ronald, Ronald, Ronald, right, that's right.

HG: But this guy I'm trying to think of did the same thing. I haven't seen him in years.

MR: How did you guys make spending money back in those days?

RA: I didn't make any. My mom gave it to me. I wasn't making no spending money at all.

MR: No?

RA: No. And you know my mom and dad was giving me money. Until I went into the service. I went into the service when I was — I had to put up my age to get into the service because I was getting a little rambunctious and mom wanted me off the street. So she took me to the Army and signed me in.

MR: No kidding?

RA: Yeah. She wanted to get me off the street.

MR: Was that '52 or something?

RA: Right, right, right. And I stayed there for three years in the service. And when I came out I had my head a little screwed on a little better, because I got into the Army and really got into the music thing because that was one way of ducking the regular Army stuff. You know like the digging the ditches and marching out and doing all that crazy stuff. So I had a chance to get into the band which put me in Special Service, and all I had to do was just make practice and make reveille and do a couple of parade things, and then play. I would play at night with bands in town, and it was kind of fun being in the Second Army band.

MR: Was the service integrated at that time?

RA: No. I was in the Army when they integrated. I was there. You know, I mean, you know they integrated the whole Army in 24 hours.

MR: Wow.

RA: They just went like, you know, like we lived on post, we lived this part of the post and all the white soldiers lived on that side of the post. Right? And we were the black outfit with all white officers and no black officers. And when I saw a black officer it was like wow, there's a black captain, can you believe this? I mean we was like amazed. Because we never seen a black officer. And one day the Master Sergeant marched us all out, marched us all out, and they did the same thing across the tracks with the white guys, and then they called names, right? They called names. And they'd say okay you guys fall out over here and you guys fall out over here, then they just meshed them. Anybody just went together, and then we went back into our barracks and we integrated. Just like that.

MR: And how did people feel about it?

RA: Oh man we had more fights than you can believe.

MR: No kidding.

RA: Oh people would be saying the "N" word and people would be saying the "C" word and they'd be making mistakes and you know just this went on for quite a while. But it got okay, you know, it got okay. But it took a while. It took a while for us to adjust to each other. Because we would just say things that we were used to saying and then go uhh — and then they'd go bang. You know, it was like pretty rough. But it was really cool. I mean it really turned out good and in the band, we didn't have no problems in the band because we had a sergeant who didn't take any stuff at all. And it was really cool. I mean I was there when they integrated the Army. The United States Army. I was on the scene. Yeah. That was something else.

MR: Was there any discrepancy in the pay you got between the white and the black soldiers?

RA: Everybody got the same money.

MR: Same money.

RA: Everybody got the same benefits. Everybody got the same everything. There wasn't no thing like that. It was just segregated, that's all. And they desegregated the Army, just like, I mean the whole United States Army they did it like that. I guess they did, because, I don't know, they did it to us. And we were in Camp Pickett Virginia when that happened.

MR: Camp what?

RA: Camp Pickett, Virginia.

MR: Okay.

RA: That was in 1953 I believe it was.

MR: Did you have any thoughts you might be sent over to Korea?

RA: Yeah. You know that was the only mistake that my mom felt that she had made is to get me in harm's way, because she insisted I go into the service because I was getting pretty stupid in the street. I had quit school, I didn't want to go to school, I didn't want to do anything other than hang out in the street, right? And so she put me in the Army and she really saved my life because I didn't go to Korea, I went to Europe instead. And it was a blessing. But I had friends that went to Korea, and I had a couple of them that got hurt over there and everything, but I went to Germany. And I spent my last 2-1/2 years in Germany in the service. So I didn't see anything like that. And I was in the Second Army Band so I had a real good, prosperous and a really good time in the Army. I learned a lot. I learned a lot about music and a lot about life.

MR: I bet you learned how to roll, huh?

RA: Yeah, I learned how to play the drums for real I learned how to play the drums, because I was in the drum corps, of course.

MR: Henry, you spent some time in a couple of music schools, right? Mastbaum? Is that how you say it?

HG: Yeah Mastbaum, that was my pre-college school, then I went to Juilliard.

RA: Mastbaum was like a vocational school, right?

HG: Yeah. Vocational/technical.

RA: Yeah, a vocational/technical school.

MR: Well when you went to Juilliard, were you learning what you wanted to learn?

HG: When I went to Juilliard I did, yes, I did. I was doing things, for instance I was, well I played the bass for choral groups and one day rehearsed, we did this chorus, I'd be the only bass player playing with these chorus groups. And that was a very challenging kind of a thing to do, you know? And but also when I went to Juilliard also I played in an opera orchestra. And it was only about two or three basses in that. And I played with that, reading, you know a lot of reading music. Music school is that way you know, which I enjoyed very much. Because it was the first thing I ever touched in a real technical sense.

You know I never had that kind of feeling before, just playing something and the feeling that it just doesn't go over that way, or some other way.

MR: It must have been good for your bowing chops too.

HG: Oh yeah, it was good for everything.

MR: But then you both got into the rhythm & blues scene. And I'm trying to get a sense of the guys you played with: Big Maybelle and so forth. Those were current pop artists at the time, in those years, right.

RA: Yeah, the Philadelphia based artists, I mean, most of them they were all out of Philadelphia: Lin Holt and he played saxophone, and actually Trane played with Lin Holt. And that was great. I got that gig with him just for a little while. And Dick Hart and the Heartaches, I played with that band.

MR: Dick Hart and the Heartaches.

RA: Dick Hart and the Heartaches, that's what they called themselves. And Big Maybelle, I played with her for a couple of jobs. And I mean you know, I mean that was the way to go. I mean that was actually, it was more or less my learning years playing with that kind of stuff. Because I always wanted to play bebop. That was my main goal. But there wasn't that many gigs to get and I wasn't all that really experienced to get those gigs yet, so I cut my teeth on playing with rhythm & blues bands for a while. And that was cool too, because what I liked about that was that Coltrane was always my idol, after seeing him with Miles Davis, and then when I look back on it, I had noticed that he had played with a lot of those bands at first, you know, when he first came through. And he also went to Granoff. So when I came out of the Army I enrolled in Granoff Music School. But that was only for a half a semester before I just got out of there. I didn't really like dealing with theory and all that kind of stuff, I really wanted to play. But I just went there because that was the place where all I thought all the bad musicians went to. So I played a lot of good rhythm & blues stuff for a while. Then I just started playing jazz.

MR: Henry, can you remember what some of those rhythm & blues gigs would have paid at the time?

HG: Well I almost forgot totally what I got paid. But it was very uplifting I remember, to get paid, because it was the most money I ever made in my life you know.

MR: Whatever it was it was the most you made.

HG: Yeah. It was the most money I ever made. And I mean a lot of it was left over and whenever they kept the money, but I mean, but it was, for instance, a musician like Willis Jackson, you could play with him and get that amount of money, so it was pretty cool.

RA: Willis Jackson.

HG: And, you know anybody like that, the pay is cool.

MR: Yeah. That's a good feeling to like get paid for something that you're loving, right?

RA: That you like to do, yeah. Yeah, it always amazed me when I got money for doing that. It always did.

MR: And eventually, did people tell you, you have to go to New York? Or did you just sort of sense that that was where —

RA: Well I mean that's where it was. Because I used to go to New York all the time. You know I would just get in the car and drive there. And catch a bus and go there. And I knew a lot of musicians in New York. But actually I had — one night John Coltrane was playing at this club in Philly called The Showboat, it was on Lombard Street, down your way. 15th and Lombard. And I was there and I was a pretty experienced drummer at that time. And I was bugging him to let me sit in and play with him, although Elvin was kicking down doors and stuff, but I still had enough heart to ask to sit in you know. But he wouldn't let me, because he had just started the band. This was in the early sixties, when he had just put this band together, with Elvin and McCoy, who was a real good friend of mine because we used to play a lot. And Reggie Workman, who also was — I mean he had my real good friends in the band, you know? And that's why I felt like I needed to get this gig. But he had this guy from Detroit, who was Elvin Jones. And so I was asking him to let me sit in and I was being stupid about it. And he was telling me no, no, you know. "I just put this band together" he'd say, but he'd say, "but you know you should go to New York, man," he'd say, "because it seems like you kind of burnt Philly up. And you should go there because there's a lot of musicians there that are thinking like you are. More or less than here in Philly." And so he sort of told me that and six months later I'm moving to New York actually.

MR: And how were you thinking? He said they were thinking like you were.

RA: Yeah well he was thinking about trying to play something other than four-four times. Trying to stretch the beat out. Trying to play a little more open and a little more freer. Because that's what they were doing, and that's why I felt like I could sit in and play with them. And he just said like there's people, and he was right, because as soon as I moved to New York, the first night that I got there, Sunny Murray, which is a friend of mine also from Philly who plays drums and he was working with Albert Ayler at the time, I sat in and played with Albert Ayler the night that I came there, right away. And then two weeks later I got a job with Don Cherry and Pharoah Sanders had just moved to New York about the same week I did and we both got a gig with Don Cherry which lasted for about four or five months at this club, at this little coffee shop over on Sullivan Street in New York. So I immediately started working when I got to New York and with Archie Schepp and all these guys who were thinking more like I was thinking. So you know it worked out really good for me. I mean as soon as I got here I got real busy.

MR: That's neat.

RA: Yeah.

MR: Henry, if my figures are right it looks like your first recording date was around 1957? Does that sound right?

HG: Pretty close.

MR: Lee Konitz perhaps?

HG: Generally in there: ’58, ’57, maybe ’56 before I left Philadelphia.
[off camera comment]

MR: Yeah that’s right I have that in here. What was — were you nervous on your first recording date? I mean I would be.

HG: I’m trying to think of who you’re referring to was on that first date? Because I had first gigs, that I call first gigs.

MR: Shafi Hadi, Pepper Adams, Wynton Kelly.

HG: Who was the leader for that?

MR: Shafi Hadi, that’s not a name I know. Shafi Hadi.

RA: Me either. Who was that?

HG: Shafi, that’s Curtis Porter.

MR: Tenor sax.

RA: Oh Curtis Porter, that’s who that was.

MR: Okay.

RA: See ‘cause Henry was a little more advanced than I was. Henry started playing with the big timers before I even thought about leaving out of Philadelphia. He did it really fast. Man this cat was, he was something else.

MR: He jumped right into it, huh?

RA: Yeah he did, man. He was playing with the big timers before I even thought about getting out of Philly.

MR: Well what was the recording dates like at that time. You showed up. Did you rehearse for them? And how long did you usually get in a record date?

HG: I don’t know. I know I did some record dates but certain things I haven’t reckoned with yet and I don’t really remember. Are you talking about rhythm & blues groups?

MR: No, no I’m talking about early on when you got into the jazz thing. It looks like you started recording like pretty actively, about once a month, around 1957.

HG: Yeah I think Lee Konitz — I did some recording with him. But the rest of them, well they weren’t recording dates. I was just playing with them, like Gerry Mulligan and Lee Konitz and Dave Bailey, the drummer from —

RA: Yeah I know him.

HG: You know Dave?

RA: Yeah.

HG: And a lot of them. Just about all of them in that circle.

MR: Was it different to play with Gerry Mulligan? He had no piano. Did that change your playing?

HG: No that may be rare, I wanted to do more. But it was a lot of, at that time it was a lot of no piano playing, that I was doing, but I also did a lot of other groups. Like you say, Shafi Hadi was one of the sidemen, you know, same as I was. I was a sideman then.

MR: I wanted to back up just a little bit. You said your family, was it Baptist? You said Holy Roller I think.

RA: Yeah right. We used to say Holy Roller, so that's like Baptist.

MR: And the music in that church was probably pretty upbeat.

RA: Very upbeat. I mean they used to like go nuts in there. I mean you ever heard of a thing called the Unknown Tone?

MR: Yes.

RA: They would get so religious and so carried away with the music until sometimes they would just faint, fall out, and then they would go start babbling [scats] stuff that you didn't even know what they were and sometimes they would have like a seizure and foam would be coming out of their mouth. And I mean that was very intense stuff. And even it didn't matter what age they were, I mean it'd be from older people to little kids who were actually — you know something like that happened to me when I was in Italy one night. Sonny Fortune and I was playing in Italy one night. And at times we used to play. I mean this is recent, maybe a couple of years ago, three or four years ago. We used to play very intense stuff. Like we would play a song, really uptempo, and we would play it for the whole set without stopping. We'd play for an hour, hour and twenty minutes. Uptempo, like "Impressions" or something, for the whole set. We'd do it for the whole set. Just the two of us — saxophone and drums. Right? And this woman was right in front of us and she stood up and fell straight back and was into convulsions and stuff. And that reminded me of when it happened in the church when I was coming up, right? She was just sitting there then all of a sudden she just leaped up in the air and screamed and fell back. And we didn't really stop, but we was on our way to stopping. And they took her out like into the restroom area and she was laid down. And we kind of came to the end of the song, and I rushed back there to see what was with her, and I looked down at her and she was just, she was kind of okay a little bit. She said, "It was the music, the music, it just like, it just" I mean she actually did one of those seizure things. Right? And I used to see that happen in the church on Sundays. Not every Sunday but sometimes they get really intense and the tambourines would be going and the people would be singing and their music would be happening, and somebody would just, "Ohhh" you know. I've seen that a lot of times. They used to call that the "Unknown Tone."

MR: Okay. And did they have another term for it, like, you know, Doris got the spirit or something?

RA: Yeah, that's what it was. I mean you know, but actually, it was like a seizure or something. You know, it was just caught up in whatever it was and just fell out. And maybe not completely fall out, but just start babbling and — but not only that but they had on staff a lot of those black churches, they had to have nurses on staff where they would actually come out and get people. They had their white gowns on and stuff, they'd come out and get people and take them to where they can rest. And they had nurses there to take care of these people. Because they were just like in those Baptist churches, we used to call them Holy Rollies as kids, right? They would just go out. The music. And it's usually the music that gets them, and the playing and the praying and the preacher would be repetitiously saying these things over and over and over again, and the music would be going on and the choir would be singing, and all of this would be going on and then somebody would just go, "Ohhhh." It was intense. Unbelievable stuff.

MR: Did that stuff find its way into your drumming?

RA: I think all of it had something to do with it. You know. I mean my whole life had something to do with what I do for a living. But that was some intense stuff. And I actually saw that happen, and when it happened in Italy, I was like wow, this is for real.

MR: Full circle.

RA: This is really for real.

MR: Did your father— what made him convert and leave that faith?

RA: I don't know what it was. You know like Philadelphia, it's a very kind of a religious kind of place. Everybody's looking for something different to be. You know. I mean they don't want to be the same as this guy. They want to be different from that guy. So maybe that's how it all went down. But whatever it was, it could have been the music too because he was definitely a person who listened to a lot of music. He used to, I mean he used to buy all the records and stuff in the house, so he had that stuff. He wasn't a musician but he just listened. He brought in records from Bird and Billie Holiday and all that kind of stuff. Well my mom was the Billie Holiday person. He'd bring in Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie and people like that, and Bud Powell.

MR: That's just so interesting to me because Mom and Dad bringing home Charlie Parker.

RA: Yeah music was played in my house all the time except Sundays, because my grandmother didn't allow jazz to be played on Sundays in the house. You can play spiritual Gospel music, like Mahalia Jackson and Rosetta Tharpe and people like that, but you couldn't play no Charlie Parker. Not on Sundays.

MR: Never on Sundays.

RA: Not on Sundays, no, no.

MR: Henry I wanted to ask you about something I read and first I thought it was like this has to be a misprint or something, but, in 1960 you did the Newport Jazz Festival?

HG: 1960?

[off camera: '58.]

MR: '58. And you played with about four different bands then? Benny Goodman and Lee Konitz, Thelonious Monk.

HG: Sonny Rollins and who else, somebody else.

[off camera: "Tony Scott."]

MR: Tony Scott. That was a heck of a weekend.

HG: Boy I don't know, I used to wonder about that myself, it's like I ran into this luck, which I wanted to do. I wanted to do some playing, and there I was playing with guys I used to know on records. And that was just a fantastic thing.

MR: That is fantastic. And the Benny Goodman group, was that his band or was that sort of a formed band for that event.

HG: That was his band. He had a big band for the Newport Jazz Festival, and a small group for other things we were playing. He had a quintet. Quintet maybe it was a septet. But somewhere halfway in between.

MR: Was he interesting to work for? I've heard a lot of stories about him.

HG: Who?

MR: Benny Goodman.

HG: Oh yeah, he's very interesting to work with. A very humorous guy.

MR: Humorous?

HG: Yeah. Certain things he'll say, that had to make you laugh. Because I think I'm bad about remembering days, and remembering who was on them, and what was who. And he was, he'd just forget days and different occasions or knowing somebody and he'd call somebody by their name totally not who the person is. And he'd sort of go through those humorous things. But playing-wise it was very good. That was the first time I'd ever played in any completely professional — you know that was a completely professional kind of gear. So I enjoyed playing with him.

MR: And the thing with Monk became part of the film, didn't it?

HG: Yeah. I never saw that.

MR: You never saw it?

HG: I saw a little bit of it on a DVD.

MR: That's pretty neat that that was captured like that. I'm trying to get a sense, you had said that Coltrane said you need to go where people are thinking like you and Henry, you've said that you guys are forward thinking. But the free jazz that was happening in the sixties in New York, did it come together — I'm not even sure how to ask this question,

but did you guys used to sit and talk about music and say well if we played this way this could happen, or did it mostly just happen on the bandstand?

RA: No we didn't, I didn't, we didn't ever really talk about it. We just did it. It was like, I mean for me, and the guys I was hanging out with, you know we didn't sit down and say now we're going to play in or we're going to play out or we going to try and play without bars, you know. It was just something that we did. Something that we heard and something that we listened to. That kind of thing. It happened spontaneously.

HG: We did a lot of things but it was never talking. It was now let's play this.

RA: Yeah it wasn't planned.

MR: It wasn't planned.

RA: It was just something that we all wanted to do, man, because we all knew what bebop was. You know, because we listened to it. We listened to it forever. And, it's just evolution to change. You know, I mean just the days and the times that we live in was different from the way it was when Bird was living, or the way it was when Satchmo was living. It was a different time. And our music reflected what was happening at that time. You know, that's what I think. And so it was time to play something different because everybody was in a different frame of mind.

MR: Can you be specific about that?

RA: Well, say Rosa Parks, you know, got on the bus one day and decided that she wasn't going to sit in the back of the bus because she was too tired. All right? And say like a bunch of service guys was on the train and we were all from New York and Pennsylvania and New Jersey, and we got on the train going down south to join a unit in the south. And on the way down south we get off at the train station and we get off because everybody wants something to eat, they're hungry and they walk to the door and they see a sign that says "colored that way, whites only." You'd see signs like that, you know? And they'd just go inside where the white place was and start taking stuff off the shelves and invading stuff and everybody gets detailed or gets in trouble or whatever. That kind of a thing was going on. So the music reflected that. You know? It reflected the hard times. That's why maybe they would say like we were playing angry music or whatever they might say it was, but it really wasn't. It was just reflecting the time of day it was. And I think we sort of outgrew the bebop era and wanted to start playing something different from what it was, because we were different people. We were not the same people as those people who lived in that bebop time. We lived in a different age. And I think that's evolution. That's how things change. Everything changes over time. People live differently. And the music reflects the way you live. That's what I think it was. So we just wanted to play something different because we was living in a different time. That's how I feel.

MR: For the bass player, for all of jazz history to that point, you were supposed to be the provider of the harmony, the root, and keep things, keep the form going that way. Did that start to change for the bass? That you could be freer.

HG: It caused more playing than I was doing. It caused more playing to be played by that means. There was bass players like Oscar Pettiford and Ray Brown and Percy Heath and bass players like that, Israel Crosby and two more, you know, very good bass players, technically. I mean you know if you wanted to get wise about anything about playing, sometime you'll want to say something or play something by one of these musicians like Percy Heath or Ray Brown.

MR: So most of your people that you listened to, you saw them in New York, you're — it's sort of people that you wanted to emulate or heard on records? Is that right?

RA: Yeah. I mean like a lot of the players that I listened to like Philly Joe Jones was my first love and Max Roach and Art Blakey and Elvin Jones, you know that changed my way of playing because I heard in Philly Joe Jones the way he stretched out phrases. You know, and he would just do it for a little while, like he would stretch the phrase out and just for maybe two or three bars, then he would go back to the swing. And I was wondering, I'd say wow, I wonder what would happen if he just kept stretching it out? Just keep stretching it out a little bit before you go back to the swing but keep in mind where the time is and where everything else is, but just keep, just keep — and then I listened to Art Blakey and Max Roach and I felt like they all, actually they all were avant garde drummers to me, because they were all playing the beat but they were just like doing little things inside the beat that I really listened to. So I've worked on that. I worked on that. And I tried to just stretch it out and elongate it until I was sort of playing that way all throughout everything else. But at the same time keeping time and keeping tempo and keeping changes running through my head but just elongating it, just letting it all just stretch out. And I think that's how I sort of developed my style of playing. And then listening to people like Cecil Taylor and — Henry played with all these people — I listened to people like Cecil and Henry Grimes and all those guys who were stretching out that stuff, right, and Sunny Murray, another drummer who was doing that, and Milford Graves, Andrew Cyrille, it was all kinds of just trying to play something different, you know, and it all came together actually. So that's how I felt about it.

MR: Henry did you ever get, in those days, playing with someone where you felt wow, I'm in way over my head here. I don't know what to do with this musician?

HG: Several times, yeah. Several times.

MR: Yeah. Can you remember who it might have been?

HG: I couldn't stop because you don't want to be representing that kind of a sound. So I'd sort of like hang in there for as much as I could do. I didn't have too much trouble but

sometimes, if that happened to me, you know I had to work myself out of it, and keep playing. But that was still great.

MR: Of all the guys that you've worked with, this could be for both of you, is there someone who was the best at giving you suggestions or directions, that helped you? Is there a person that comes to mind?

RA: Coltrane for me.

MR: Coltrane for you?

RA: He was my guru man. He was my everything. He did, as far as I'm concerned, he did it all. And I was very fortunate that he took a liking to me and brought me in and sort of directed — well not directed — but sort of gave me the privilege to explore my playing. He helped me to develop what I was trying to do. Because he saw what I was trying to do. And he just put me in a position to develop it. And he told me that, because Miles Davis did the same thing for him. He saw the potential in Coltrane and he put him in a position where he can develop that stuff that he was doing. And the same thing happened for me. John brought me in there knowing that I had something, and just gave me a chance to do it. And he would always say, "All you need to do," and I always tell young musicians, ones that I like a lot, "all you need to do is to keep playing. Just get with somebody that you can play and it will come to you." And I don't care what it is that your playing, as long as you're playing and searching and trying to do this it will happen for you. So I think he made it happen for me. He gave me a chance to make it happen.

MR: Was there other things besides just the music that you gained from him also?

RA: Yeah, I gained how to be a better person. I know I gained — because I had a pretty — I had an ego. I was completely egotistical when I was coming up. I felt like, you know, I was playing with Coltrane, I was the best that ever lived, you know, I was the only thing that ever happened on this earth you know, because I was working with the greatest saxophonist in the world. And I felt like I was all that. And there's a story I used to tell, I told Coltrane once, he asked me about this musician. You know, he said, "Rashied there's a musician out there asking me to sit in," you know, and he said, "and he also said that he had played with you before." And he said, "What do you think, what do you think?" you know. He always used to come at me with stuff like that. "What do you think, should I let him play" or something. And I said, "Oh man, that cat can't play shit," you know. And he said, "Oh really?" I said, "Man, he ain't playing shit man." You know what he did when he went out on the bandstand, the first thing he did was say, "Hey man, come on up and play." And I felt like I wanted to disappear behind the drumset. I felt too bad because I put the cat down without even thinking about anything. And I was very quiet for the rest of the night, I wasn't saying anything to nobody. And he said, "You know" (I'm not going to mention his name, he's not here anymore anyways) he said, "you know," he

said, “what do you think about this guy” who was playing. Of course I wasn’t going to say anything else bad about him. I said, “Well you know.” He said, “Well you know, Rashied,” he said “I’m going to tell you man,” he said, “I don’t care how bad or how good you think a person is playing music. I say if he’s playing music” he said “there’s always something you can get out of it if you listen. It might not be something you can use, but it might be something you can use, I mean I don’t care how bad you think he plays or whatever, but there could be something there that you can get from it if you listen.” And I never went at a person like that again. You know I never talked bad about a person since then. Because, so I mean I learned a lot of stuff from John, as to how to be as a person. And you know, give people a break. Don’t talk down on musicians, especially if it’s about music. So I learned quite a bit from him as a youngster coming up. And it works for me too, because I have a lot of respect for everybody and you learn a lot when you respect people. Because you’re not closed minded. You don’t think like you know, because I feel like when you’re closed minded and think you’re all that, that’s when I think you stop learning. You can’t learn anything no more because you think you know everything. And then you start going that way instead of this way. As long as you keep your mind open, like John and Cecil Taylor and all those cats, they keep their mind open. They embrace what people are doing. They listen. And that’s how you become a great whatever-you-are trying to be behind just listening to people and being able to absorb stuff. And I learned that.

MR: Good lesson.

RA: Yeah.

MR: Henry, was there somebody in your past that you really felt that set you on — or helped you on your musical career and your path that you were trying to take?

HG: Yes, a lot of professional musicians like Max Roach or the Prez, you know a lot of musicians like that I’ve played with and you know I’d have to go through my struggle up there, which they encouraged me about that.

MR: I always felt like the bass player had a lot of responsibility. Because first, I mean if you don’t know the tune, who’s going to hear it? A saxophone player can sort of negotiate things by listening to the bass player. But who’s the bass player listening to?

HG: Yeah well the bass player is listening to everybody including the drummer and everybody else that’s playing something into it. But for instance like lately I’ve been listening to bass players that don’t — they stop playing what they think musicians hear when you play, like I mean it’s just like they hear any music at all, any sheet music or anything that has notes on it and nothing, and it might be something that they never heard of, you know, just like he says, told him to come up there and get on the stand and play. You know a lot of those things are part of the challenge, it might come to you anyway.

MR: When you guys work together, or this may happen in other combinations; I know you work with a lot of different people. If something, if you're playing a song that is not preconceived, are there times when you're playing together where you feel like we're sort of just marking time here, waiting for something to gel?

HG: Yeah, it's true, but I think it's more of a guess than accurate. You know, what's going to be coming. But that's a thought because when a lot of the rhetorics and pragmatics, there are a lot of guys playing, you know kind of do certain meaning in their playing and in others' and it's all happening at once. You know, that may not necessarily mean it as a sign of times to come, something that is, you know, that kind of a sign. It's not really that way.

MR: Rashied, how do you know when, like if I look on your CD here and there's a song that's twenty-some minutes long, is there something inside you guys that tells you this one's over now?

RA: Well we work on each other's — we work with each other on things and we listen to each other and we kind of work off of each other, you know. You sort of just bounce off of each other. Like Henry would get into an idea of something and I would catch up to it sometimes, or sometimes I can't, or maybe I'll be struggling trying to deal with it. But not struggling to the point where you can notice it at all, just within myself. And then I say oh, here's where it's at. And I will get there and when I get there sometimes Henry would be going someplace else. All right? Now I'm after it again. It's just that it's like we are playing tag you know. I catch up and then it's like wow, then I'm looking again and I catch up and then we come together with all this stuff and then we'll be apart, then we're together, then I'm after him then he's after me. And it's just like that. So it's very exciting, I mean for the listener, but sometimes I'll be hurting up there. But, at the same time, it's a good hurt. It's something that is challenging I would say, it's very challenging.

MR: Is there one of your hands or feet or one of your instruments that you find when you're not really comfortable, and as you said you're trying to find out where is it, whatever it is, do you find that you rely on something just to play more until you can really find it —

RA: Well yeah, well you know I definitely have something that I can fall back on. You know I mean I have something that, I mean that's my experience and my prowess and my experience, that I pull on everything when I'm playing just with Henry because I'm dealing with just the bass. You know I'm not dealing with horns and piano and all that. So I have to rely on my experience and prowess and so a lot of times I could get something, I could pull up on something that would get me through the mass, you know. It can get me through the uneasiness until I can catch up to what's happening. Now I don't stop, I just keep going until it comes into view and then I'm okay again. And that

lasts until it changes again. So, because it's always different, it's always changing. And then we keep up some stuff for maybe 20 minutes or 25 minutes, and then after a while we'll sort of look at each other and go okay, this is, it's time to leave this now. And bang, we quit. You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah. Neat. Henry, the years you spent out of the music business, were you still listening to music? Did you have an opportunity to listen to what was going on?

HG: I wasn't, no. I was listening to Texas Mexican music.

MR: Oh.

HG: Or I'd listen to a lot of — what's the name of that other kind of Mexican music where there are seven different kinds of music that they play.

MR: Mariachi?

HG: Yeah, Mariachi. And a lot of Chinese and all things like that, all kinds of things like that. Or different kinds of — but my favorite was the Texas Mex.

MR: Tex Mex music. I'll be darned.

HG: But you know I used to listen to that. But I didn't have — all I had was a TV and sometimes I'd catch some things on TV maybe slightly, but very, very slightly, because of what I had on my mind.

MR: Okay. Were you surprised at the change in technology when you eventually went back into the studio to record and what had happened with how things are done?

HG: No, I'm not that aware of it. Just like a lot of technology that has occurred between then and now, and also, well for many years it's always been a thing of technology and sounds and electronics and hooked up with music.

MR: The years when you weren't playing, is that when your poetry really became a vital part of what you were doing?

HG: Yeah, when I had nothing to do, like I quit that, and I write poetry. And sometimes I might be thinking about like how do I favor a beat or something like that, but that was just an idea to make music but also all kinds of metric ideas you know. Poetry or music. But I wasn't listening to music at that time, so that was a long time ago, that was about 30 years.

MR: Well you made a big impression when you came back.

HG: Yeah. I know what you mean.

MR: I look at your upcoming calendar. It looks pretty healthy to me. There's words that I've noticed from both of you on your CDs and in your poetry book, that seem to occur pretty often: forces, aggregate and things about rituals and I love this word "easternal mysticism." What are the rituals that you are referring to?

RA: You'll have to ask Henry about that.

MR: Okay. What are the rituals?

RA: Because that's his words.

HG: Yeah, uh going east. Like it's easternal when you go east. You know like that. The sun rises in the east or you know, impulses derive their existence coming from the east or like that. And because I was writing that I had something to do instead of watching TV, after work, I'd do that, I'd write after work, essentially that's what it is. But yeah, I'm glad somebody heard my poetry. I didn't expect that to happen.

MR: Yeah. Isn't that interesting. I hear you've got quite a collection too.

HG: Yeah, I've got to do something, however you do that, you know, but I'm open for suggestions.

[off camera]

I think it was also a reference to coming back to New York, which he was predicting to himself and preparing himself for.

MR: Coming back from the west coast to the east coast.

HG: Yeah, that also, because that gives you the opportunity to come from some source and understanding. You know that's a whole source right there, you know, if you're going to return to music or return from music. You know it's a lot of knowledge in that, I mean a lot of understanding and a lot of, nothing is something you can really take for granted but you know it's there. All those things can really come together and make a metaphor and it becomes a metaphor. I mean it can, but you might do something else. I'm not saying do that, it might be something else.

MR: You know you were talking the other day, I guess yesterday, about the effort that you made, both of you, back a number of years ago to get free or avant garde jazz on some of these festivals, that they weren't presenting that spectrum of the music. And in the last year or so I went to a big jazz convention and the people that promote Dixieland music, or very early, were complaining about the same thing. And it's like they're leaving out the ends of the music. Do you agree with that? And can you tell me about —

RA: Well back, like in the 70s, like the early part of the 70s, I don't know too much about the Dixieland but probably all even Dixieland and avant garde now, but not now, not so much now, because the avant garde is really popular in Europe. And I mean you know we get like huge crowds in Europe with this stuff. And it's festivals attracts a lot of people from all around. But actually it really got a hold there more or less more so than here. In fact, most of the European players that play jazz are into avant garde more than anything else. Some of the fusion stuff works too a little bit, you know, like the cut from the "Bitches Brew" era, and stuff, but a lot of the music is very avant garde there in Europe. And so like here, in America, it's alive but not well. You know it's alive here. You can find this stuff in just about every major city. You know you find a place that caters to this kind of music in just about every major city. Like one club maybe or something. And

then even some of the main jazz clubs will hire like the really name avant garde players like Cecil Taylor or Ornette Coleman and sometimes I even get a shot at it too, because I'm sort of like an old-timer now. And so we get to play in a lot of the major clubs here now. But in the 70s it wasn't about to be had, you know. We were hurting for places to play, we were hurting for recording companies to record us, so we were forced to start our own kind of venues. We went into like into loft situations in New York City and people started fixing up lofts and putting on their own concerts and putting on their own things, they called it "loft jazz" or "loft times" and then we started putting out our own records, actually the whole deal. Like recording them, pressing them up, and selling them on our own or either taking them to distributors and getting a deal with the distributors to put them out and to get them around to record stores and stuff like that. You know. So actually we were like self-made in the 70s because we wasn't getting any help from the major companies or the major clubs you know. But we survived. We survived. We got people to come out to listen to us, we sold our records, and then I mean we did so well we even had our own jazz festival called the New York Jazz Musicians' Festival which was a festival that sort of bumped heads with George Wein's Newport Festival, because no avant garde festival was on that. And we sort of put a dent in their thing. We got a lot of people that was coming from Europe, and they was coming to hear us more than going down to Carnegie Hall and listening to, you know, what George Wein had. And so George Wein made a deal with us actually to make us a part of his festival, which was unheard of. And so we did that, I mean that's a long story. I didn't get involved in it because I felt like a lot of things that wasn't being done that should have been done, but some of us went and George Wein got them a place and advertised it on his Newport stuff and got avant garde people a venue, a couple of venues, for them to play on his festival as well. And then a lot of the clubs started giving us jobs, because we had our own places anyway, to play, so they just got in on the act. And so actually man, we were kind of self-made. We sort of forced them to recognize who we were and what we were doing, and giving us employment and giving us gigs and giving us record dates.

MR: Was that something like with the October Revolution?

RA: That was one of the beginnings of it.

MR: Yeah. Okay.

RA: That was one of the beginnings of it, you know, like Cecil Taylor and Bill Dixon and because I was playing with Bill Dixon at that time. And Cecil Taylor, Bill Dixon and Carla Bley and Paul Bley, and different people like that. They started that October Revolution, actually Bill Dixon was one of the main things in that. And then they got the JOC thing too, which started a record distributing company and so that encouraged people to make their own records and JVC, uh, not JVC, JCOA.

MR: Jazz Composers—

RA: Composers Orchestra Guild. And they got a distributor thing going on and they would distribute our records if we made them and get them to them. It was LPs at that time. And they would distribute it for us, and they had a pretty good, wide range of distributing, and they would get them all over America to different record companies and so we sort of got a little bit of play behind that. And got a little independent too as well. So we sort of got jobs, you know. They started reaching out and getting us on some of us on these jobs. I think that's really how it got started. It was sort of like we sort of were like competition, especially in New York City. You figure if you come to New York then you have to deal with the jazz musician festivals and have to deal with avant garde jazz musicians. And that's sort of helped the situation out a little bit.

MR: I see. How are we doing for time, Mary? Eight minutes? You know it feels really good to be able to say President Obama these days.

RA: Yeah.

MR: About eight days he's been, eight or nine days. I wonder how — you guys have any —

RA: It feels even better because Obama says he likes John Coltrane. You know that's even feeling better, because he said, in one of his speeches, that he gave his brother-in-law "A Love Supreme." Because he was playing, see he was playing a lot of music, man, he'd say, "Now I really want you to hear something." He's trying to get his music together. He said "I want you to really hear something really great." So he said, "I gave him John Coltrane's 'A Love Supreme'." So right there, when Obama said that I go like wow, this cat is into the music. So it's very possible he could have "Interstellar Space" there in his house or something. You know? Because he openly spoke of John Coltrane, and I never ever heard a president speak of John Coltrane. You know? So that also, why I went oh wow, we've really got somebody in the White House, it's really possible — Cecil Taylor played in the White House, I think it was under Bill Clinton, because he had a saxophone, you know, Bill Clinton had a saxophone. In fact I got his CD, Bill Clinton's CD when he played saxophone.

MR: I didn't know such a thing existed.

RA: Yeah. It did. And I bought it right away and I never played it. I figure I played it once, but I just kept it for archives. And so like Obama's talking about Coltrane, so like it could be possible one day to play the White House. It would be great.

MR: Yeah. Avant garde at the White House.

RA: Yeah, because he definitely said that he was giving his brother-in-law "A Love Supreme." He said that. I went like wow. So Obama is really, he's really the cat and he's trying to do it all.

MR: Yeah. Very hopeful.

RA: Very hopeful, yeah.

MR: Henry, I see you're doing something coming up at Berklee?

HG: Yes.

MR: And the New England Conservatory? Man. You guys, I just love to see the arc of a career like that. And that's really great.

HG: Thank you, man.

MR: And I look forward to hearing you guys perform tomorrow night. I'm going to be fascinated to — I think if there's a type of jazz that I really need to know more about personally I think it's what you guys do. So I'm going to be watching and listening very intently. I'm trying to figure out the level of spontaneity and structure and all that, and how that works.

RA: Well if you keep in mind that it's bass and drums, that would like get you over the hump, you know what I mean? Keeping that in mind. Because it's a lot different from a full quartet or a quintet or whatever. Or even a duo with drums and saxophone or a duo with bass and saxophone. You know, this is two rhythm instruments playing together. And of course Henry has taken over the melodic structures as well as playing rhythmically. And I'm doing the best I can with the melodic stuff, as a drummer. Yeah I'm doing the best I can with the melodic stuff, being a drummer, but I hear melodically. So I approach the drums in a very different way than most drummers.

MR: Well it's been fascinating meeting you guys and getting to know you, and I look forward to the concert. And I want to thank you for your time.

RA: Great. Yeah thank you. And thanks for having us up here. It was really good, okay.

MR: All right.